



(L TO R) THE FOUR-IDOL STATUE RECOVERED IN JOGIDA; THE SEAT OF THE HEAD BUDDHIST MONK ATOP JOGIDA; BROKEN PIECES OF POTTERY DATING BACK TO THE 3RD OR 4TH CENTURY B.C.

of three hills at the bottom of which is a natural perennial stream, dammed by local inhabitants. Rawat, who was part of the famous team that excavated Dholavira in Kutch, the biggest Indus Valley civilisation site after Mohenjodaro and Harappa, says that such a find comes very rarely.

The first indication of Buddhist influence in the Taranga Hills came in 1936 when A.S. Gadre, the chief archaeologist of the then ruler of Baroda, Sayajirao Gaekwad, examined two idols of goddesses and Buddha that today sit in the Dharanmata and Taranmata temples and are worshipped by locals. Gadre said they were both from the 9th century A.D. The idol known as Dharanmata was identified as Taradevi, a goddess of Tantrik Buddhism. Though Gadre left some description of the idols, none of the scholars explored the area from the Buddhist angle till Rawat surveyed the area three months ago. An exercise lasting 10 days yielded the most conclusive evidence that the Buddhist settlement actually dated back to the 3rd century B.C., much earlier than 9th century A.D. as observed by Gadre.

Former director-general of the Archaeological Survey of India R.S. Bist says, "The new findings at



Such an interesting Buddhist settlement made out of natural rock shelters has not been found yet.

Y.S. RAWAT, *Archaeologist*

Taranga are very significant when it comes to establishing a Buddhist influence in the state when seen with the discoveries of Dev Ni Mori and the Vadnagar monastery." Bist is also excited about Rawat's assumption that the south-eastern side of Taranga could have been the famous ancient Anartapur. The Buddhist stupa of Dev Ni Mori was discovered by a team of archaeologists led by S.N. Chaudhary of the Maharaja Sayajirao University (MSU), Baroda, in the early 1960s and ranks as one of the most important Buddhist discoveries in western India in the last century. According to Rawat, the natural rock shelters in the hills were home to the monks. While exploring, he came across many interesting objects feeding the Buddhist theory—

two broken terracotta statues of the Buddha sitting in the Padmasana posture and pottery of the Kshatrapa (1st to 4th century A.D.) and pre-Kshatrapa period (1st to 3rd century B.C.).

Senior archaeologist K. Krishnan says, "Rawat's findings establish that Gujarat was majorly influenced by Buddhism." The three hills that comprise the Buddhist settlement are without a fort wall and located towards the west of Taranga. But the area that has the Jain temples is located on the south-western side of Taranga with a fort wall. Rawat says, "This was a Buddhist settlement before the Jains came. However, both seem to have flourished at two different spots in the same area."

A detailed documentation along with excavations is required in areas where more relics can be found. Ideally, this could be around the place where Rawat discovered two broken Buddha statues and the spot from where the pottery was recovered. Excavations need to be carried out around the ancient walls in the Jain-dominated south-eastern side of the Taranga Hills also to supplement the Anartapur theory. If archaeologists do lay their hands upon inscriptions supporting the theory, it will amount to an archaeological goldmine. ■